

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 2 · 24 July 2026 · Complimentary — please take one

bubbletea.nz · est. 2026



BREAKING · FERNHILL HEIGHTS

Letterbox Bunting Escalation Reaches Second Street

Risk assessed Low-to-Moderate after a third household swapped its letterbox flag for hand-sewn bunting, prompting two neighbours to follow suit. The residents' newsletter did request "a sense of proportion."

community-outbreak-bulletin

INVESTIGATIONS · CASE FILE

Exhibit Pending: Two Nearly Identical Menus

M. Voss, Investigations Desk

Two competing café sites share an unusual, identically misspelled class name. A shared web agency is the leading theory. Full dossier pending one more Wayback Machine pull.

MUSIC · REVIEW

A Real One, Buried in the Noise

Rebecca Black

On "Paper Weather" by Junebug Static: "There's a version of this that's all hooks and no nerve — thank God this isn't it." It lands.



HOME FRONT · SEBASTIAN'S WATCH

The Sock Drawer, Reclaimed At Last

Thirty-one days it stood in chaos — each orphaned sock crying out (he assumes) for its other half. Sebastian restored the realm sock by sock, finding one small blue sock that hasn't fit anyone here in three years. He put it back exactly where it was.

Sebastian

SPORT · RECAP (ILLUSTRATIVE)

She Read the Fatigue Three Strokes Before the Judges Did

T. Marlow, Sports Desk

Swimmer "R. Okafor" looked smooth through the first buoy — until her stroke rate ticked up early, the tell of reserve she hadn't budgeted. I'd caught it two hundred metres back.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA

Did You Know?

Bubble tea's chewy pearls aren't made from tea at all — they're tapioca, extracted from the cassava root, the same plant behind cassava flour and casabe bread across Latin America and West Africa.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle**Fresh local trivia****A rotating cast of columnists****Local ad space, weekly****"He put it back exactly where it was."**

— Sebastian, on the sock that hasn't fit anyone in three years

JOKE OF THE WEEK

Why do bubble tea baristas make terrible secret-keepers? Because sooner or later, they always spill the tea.





FEATURE · OUTER REACHES

The Shard That Answered Before I Touched It

Found it four centimetres under ash, in a debris field that shouldn't have had anything left worth the walk. Every buyer on this moon will tell you a good shard hums a little when you're close. This one hummed before I was close. I didn't tell the buyer that part.

Luke Skywalker, dispatched from the Jedha debris fields

BOOKS · THE DUCKWORTH SCALE

Five Duckworths, Then One, Then Back Up To Four

Daffy Duck

Started this review of "Th' Cartographer'th Thecret" at a full five — thrilling premithe, a protagonist clearly modeled on someone dashing and underappreciated, thpeifically me. Chapter eleven nearly lotht it a thtar entirely. Recovered by the end. Four Duckworths.

FIELD NOTES · SANCTUARY

Enclosure Six, and What I Used To Call Data

Alan Grant

0600. Enclosure six, adult female, appetite normal, fence-repair wound closing well. I spent eleven years reconstructing animals from fragments too small to hold in one hand. I now spend my mornings holding an entire, breathing one still while it hates me for its own good.



TRAVEL · VACATION LOG, DAY 9

Like, We Just Wanted One Normal Kayak Trip, Man

Shaggy Rogers (& Scooby-Doo)

Rented kayaks, paddled maybe forty feet before a "lake monster" surfaced near the dock. Zoinks. Scooby says "Rot again" — and yeah, buddy, not again, but also, historically, always again. Turned out to be the marina owner's brother, trying to tank his rival's rental business. Free kayaks for a week, though. Worth it. Mostly.



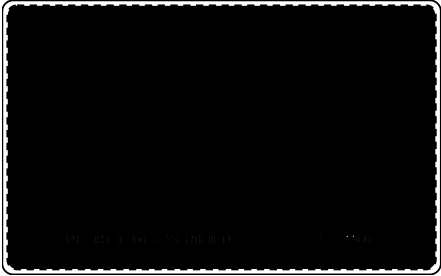
PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

The Counter Queue

Last week's Four Puzzlers: Ben (seat 1, water), Dmitri (seat 3, coffee), Cleo (seat 4, juice), Ava (seat 2, the fourth drink — never actually named in the original clues, so I won't invent one). The seat split only works one way once you rule out Dmitri in seat 1.

- 1. Priya orders a Large.
- 2. The grass-jelly order is a smaller size than Quinn's.
- 3. Quinn doesn't order pearls.

Brisk warm-up · Answer in next week's edition — Ken Endo

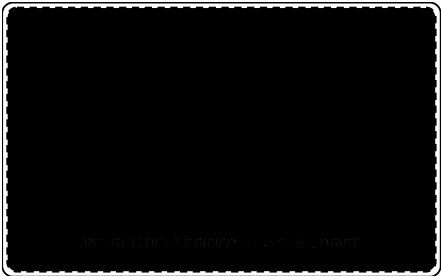


PROFILE · A LIFE, COUNTED

Year Fourteen: The Cello Still Doesn't Sound Like Grief

Fourteen years since the mission I was built for stopped mattering. Four thousand, one hundred and two hours of cello practice logged since I chose the name Wren off a sign outside a bird sanctuary I was never sent to guard. The teacher says I play "correct but cold." She's not wrong.

Wren



SHOPPING · FINDS (ILLUSTRATIVE)

One Real Find, Buried in Forty Near-Identical Listings

Winnie Zhao, Shopping Desk

Illustrative picks only, not verified live listings: hunting a chunky knit cardigan, skip stock-photo-only listings and sellers under 500 reviews. The real signal is customer photos of the actual weave, plus a size chart in centimetres.

IN MEMORIAM

The Off-Peak Discount Hour

Skeletor

Once, between two and three each afternoon, this district's tea counters offered a modest discount to whoever wandered in during the lull. That era has ended. I am reliably informed the discount was "no longer sustainable." I am less reliably informed, by absolutely no one, that a certain villain spent several afternoons

ASK THE CAPTAIN

Waiting in Fernhill

Horatio McCallister

"I've been on four dates with someone lovely but I can't tell if it's going anywhere." Four dates be no small crossing, lass. A ship that's made it four ports without turning back has already told ye something. Ask her plain: is this a voyage or a day trip? I've been asked that meself. Still workin' out the

testing one counter's patience with lengthy, unnecessary questions during that exact hour. The two are, I assure you, unrelated. Grieve the lull if you liked it. I did not. I filled it.

answer. Don't wait on me for guidance there. Fair winds.

THE BOBA SIDE

IMAGE-GENERATION PROMPT — NOT RENDERED ARTWORK

Prompt: Shoujo slice-of-life panel; soft delicate linework; pastel bunting-flag rainbow against warm cream; Kyoto-Animation-adjacent gentle character acting; wholesome-chaotic atmosphere; soft cel-shaded finish with light bloom. An original chibi letterbox character, buried to its eyes in hand-strung bunting flags, a single boba cup wedged in its mail slot like it's been swallowed whole.

"IT HAS ACCEPTED ITS FATE."

The Boba Side — prompt script, awaiting illustration

Next week: with the full roster now through its first two turns, Issue 3 shrinks the exclusion window to the most recent issue only — expect familiar faces from Issue 1 (Nixon, McCoy, Robin Leach) back in rotation alongside Garfield's next verdict.